

ENG 111: Public Speaking

- Lecture 2: Ethics and Public Speaking
- Fall 2026
- Chapter 2 focus: ethical communication and responsible public speaking

Today's Class

- Recap and warm-up — 10 min
- What is ethics? — 15 min
- Why ethics matters — 15 min
- Ethical responsibilities — 20 min
- Ethical listening — 10 min
- Case studies — 15 min
- Wrap-up — 5 min

Warm-Up: Can a Good Speech Be Unethical?

- Scenario: A speaker delivers a confident, well-organized speech.
- The audience applauds enthusiastically.
- Later, the audience learns that the speaker invented several statistics.
- DISCUSS: Was it a good speech? Was it an ethical speech? Why?
- Example response: It may have been effective in presentation, but it was unethical because the speaker deliberately misled the audience.

What Do We Mean by Ethics?

- Ethics concerns questions of right and wrong in human behaviour.
- In public speaking, ethics guides how we use information, language, evidence, and persuasive power.
- Example: If you know a statistic is unreliable but use it because it supports your argument, the problem is ethical—not merely technical.

Why Does Ethics Matter?

- Speakers can influence what audiences think, believe, feel, decide, and do.
- EXAMPLE: A student leader speaks about whether students should support a campus policy.
- If the leader gives accurate information, listeners can make an informed decision. If important facts are deliberately hidden, the audience may be manipulated.

Public Speaking Is Powerful

- Words can inform, inspire, persuade, mislead, or harm.
- EXAMPLE: Compare these statements:
- “Please recycle because waste affects our environment.”
- “Anyone who does not recycle is a terrible and irresponsible person.”
- DISCUSS: Which approach is more responsible? How can language influence an audience emotionally?

Ethics and Credibility

- Credibility is closely connected to whether an audience sees a speaker as trustworthy.
- It can be strengthened through accuracy, honesty, fairness, respect, and responsible evidence.
- EXAMPLE: If you admit, “There are different views on this issue, but the evidence I found suggests...,” you may appear more credible than if you exaggerate certainty.

Responsibility 1: Be Honest

- Do not knowingly present false information or invent evidence.
- EXAMPLE: You are giving a speech on online learning.
- You cannot find evidence that “90% of all students dislike online classes,” but you use the number because it sounds convincing.
- This is unethical because the statistic is fabricated.

Quick Discussion

- A speaker says: “Everyone agrees that social media is harmful.”
- DISCUSS: What is wrong with this statement?
- Possible points: It is an unsupported generalization; “everyone” is unlikely to be accurate; it ignores different experiences and perspectives.
- How could it be revised? Example: “Some researchers and users have raised concerns about the harmful effects of excessive social media use.”

Responsibility 2: Use Evidence Responsibly

- Use evidence that genuinely supports your claim.
- Check the original source where possible.
- Do not quote information out of context.
- EXAMPLE: A report says, “Some first-year students experienced stress during online learning.”
- Unethical distortion: “The report proves that online learning causes stress for all students.”

Responsibility 3: Avoid Plagiarism

- Do not present another person's words or ideas as your own.
- EXAMPLE: You find a paragraph online explaining climate change and copy it directly into your speech without acknowledging the source.
- Even if you deliver it confidently, the work is not ethically yours.
- Better practice: Paraphrase carefully and acknowledge the source when required.

Responsibility 4: Respect the Audience

- Do not deliberately humiliate, deceive, or unfairly exploit listeners.
- EXAMPLE: During a speech, a presenter says, “Only ignorant people disagree with me.”
- DISCUSS: Why might this be unethical?
- It attacks audience members rather than engaging with their ideas and may pressure people through humiliation.

Responsibility 5: Respect Different Views

- Persuasion does not require personal attacks.
- Compare:
- Personal attack: “My opponent is stupid, so you should reject the proposal.”
- Responsible criticism: “I disagree with the proposal because its evidence does not address the financial costs.”
- Which statement focuses on the issue rather than the person?

Ethics in Persuasive Speaking

- Persuasion itself is not unethical.
- The ethical question is HOW persuasion is used.
- Example: A speaker encourages students to wear seat belts using accurate accident data and reasonable arguments.
- Contrast: A speaker invents frightening stories to create panic and force agreement.
- DISCUSS: Where is the line between persuasion and manipulation?

Ethics and Emotional Appeals

- Emotion can make a speech meaningful and memorable.
- However, emotion should not replace truth.
- EXAMPLE: A speaker discussing road safety tells a genuine story about a family affected by an accident and connects it to evidence-based safety recommendations.
- Question: Why might this be ethically different from inventing a tragic story simply to make the audience cry?

The Audience Has Responsibilities Too

- Ethical communication is not only the speaker's responsibility.
- Listeners should listen carefully, evaluate evidence, remain open to reasonable arguments, and avoid rushing to judgment.
- EXAMPLE: A speaker makes a claim that sounds convincing because they speak confidently.
- An ethical listener asks: “What evidence supports this claim?” rather than accepting it automatically.

Ethical Listening: Mini Exercise

- Claim: “Artificial intelligence will completely replace teachers within five years.”
- Before accepting the statement, ask:
 - Who made this claim?
 - What evidence is provided?
 - Is the prediction presented as fact?
 - Are there alternative views?
- DISCUSS: What additional information would you need before believing or sharing the claim?

Case Study 1: The Unchecked Statistic

- A student gives a persuasive speech about social media.
- The student finds a statistic on an unknown website and presents it as unquestionable fact.
- The original source is never checked.
- DISCUSS IN PAIRS:
 1. What is the ethical problem?
 2. What could happen if the statistic is false?
 3. What should the student do before using it?

Case Study 1: Example Discussion

- Possible answer:
- The student has a responsibility to verify whether the information is credible and accurate.
- If the statistic is false, the audience may make decisions based on misinformation.
- Better approach: Locate the original source, evaluate its credibility, and represent the finding accurately.

Case Study 2: The Emotional Appeal

- A speaker wants the audience to support a social cause.
- The speaker tells an extremely emotional story but deliberately leaves out facts that might make the issue more complicated.
- DISCUSS:
- Is this ethical persuasion? Why or why not?
- How could the speaker remain persuasive while presenting the issue more fairly?

Group Activity: Ethical or Unethical?

- In groups of 3–4, choose one scenario:
- A. A speaker changes a quotation so it appears to support the opposite view.
- B. A speaker uses a true statistic but does not explain its limitations.
- C. A speaker respectfully presents opposing views before explaining their own position.
- D. A speaker exaggerates a problem because they believe the audience will otherwise ignore it.
- For your scenario: identify the ethical issue, explain your reasoning, and suggest a better approach.

Sample Group Response

- Scenario A: Changing a quotation.
- Why unethical? It misrepresents what the original speaker actually said.
- Possible consequence: The audience forms an opinion based on distorted information.
- Better approach: Quote accurately, provide context, and explain honestly why you agree or disagree.

A Speaker's Ethical Checklist

- Before speaking, ask:
- Is my information accurate?
- Have I checked important evidence?
- Am I representing sources fairly?
- Have I acknowledged others' work appropriately?
- Am I respecting my audience and people who hold different views?
- Am I persuading responsibly rather than deliberately deceiving?

Connecting Ethics to Your Speeches

- This semester you will deliver impromptu, informative, persuasive, and group speeches.
- EXAMPLE: In an informative speech, accuracy is essential.
- In a persuasive speech, evidence and fair representation are essential.
- In an impromptu speech, avoid inventing facts when you are unsure.
- In group work, acknowledge contributions and work responsibly with others.

Exit Ticket

- Write briefly:
- 1. Name one ethical responsibility of a public speaker.
- 2. Give one example of unethical communication.
- 3. Complete the sentence: “An ethical speaker should...”
- Example: “An ethical speaker should verify important information before presenting it as fact.”

Next Class

- Next topic: Verbal Messages
- Think about this question before our next class:
- Can two people hear the same words but understand them differently?
- Bring one real-life example of a misunderstanding caused by words or language.
- Thank you!